

What Is the Point of Learning English, After All?

Zhihu

The purpose of human language learning is certainly communication. Only when there is a need to communicate with English speakers is there a need to learn English; if it is only for exams, its significance is indeed limited. But I believe the questioner's aim is to explore, at a deeper and broader level, whether the Chinese really need to learn English at all.

Before 2020, China's overall strength was below America's, so the whole society had no great doubts about learning English. In a world where the United States and its allied blocs occupied the high-end industries and scientific research, English's position as the common language could not be challenged. Whether for studying abroad, trade with America, science and technology, or international travel, learning English was a key link in improving one's personal quality.

But after 2020, with China's industrial upgrading and its strength gradually surpassing America's — including metrics like the Nature Index — many people began to consider another possibility: in a number of years, China's overall strength may far exceed America's, even surpassing the sum of the developed countries of Europe and America. In that case, not only would Chinese at home have no need of English to keep up with frontier technology; even the language of foreign trade could switch to Chinese. This voice is rising within China — not only widespread on the internet, but present in real life as well. I myself work for a multinational corporation and communicate with foreign colleagues in English, yet recently I have heard colleagues say things like "in the future everyone will speak Chinese; there is no need to learn English." How to view this opinion is a meaningful question for people living in the 2020s, especially for parents.

Before the 1980s, foreign languages were basically monopolised by elites and professionals; ordinary people spoke only their dialect and their country's official language, not any foreign tongue. This was true not only of China but of most countries. The popularisation of foreign languages among ordinary people began only after the 1980s, because in the 1980s the paradigm of globalisation changed fundamentally.

Before the 1980s, globalisation was mainly the globalisation of commodity trade; the chief intercourse between countries was trade in goods, so foreign languages were used mainly in foreign trade, politics, tourism, and similar fields — a specialised skill. After the 1980s, the development of ICT technology made the transnational layout of production within the same industry possible, and the multinational corporation needs a unified language within its walls: not only professional translators, but ordinary engineers must know the common language (at least to read) in order to

work. And in the era when America was the sole superpower of the capitalist world, English naturally filled that position.

In the era of China's rise, will English lose this position? If English loses it and Chinese takes its place, then indeed the Chinese have little need to learn English — after all, wherever you go there will be plenty of people who know Chinese. Unless out of a taste for the culture of English-speaking countries, or a need to work there, there would be no reason to learn it.

In the age of globalisation, language has become so important. For a country, investing in education in the global lingua franca is investing in the future of its citizens. In the former French colonies, a desire has spread among the young to reject French and replace it with English; this is especially evident in Morocco, Algeria, and the like. In the emerging countries, facing the real challenges of integrating into global industrial chains and the subsequent industrial upgrading and enterprises going overseas, how to empower citizens linguistically has also become a critical question. In some countries this choice even rises to the level of national strategy — Singapore, Rwanda, and most recently Vietnam. On Vietnam, I gave an answer earlier, for reference:

"How Should We View Vietnam's Policy of Making English the Foundation of the Nation?" — answer by 最最遥远的路 on Zhihu: <https://www.zhihu.com/answer/1975262743335572155>

Because China is a populous country with advanced industry and science, its drive to integrate is not as urgent as Vietnam's. But the question of the international lingua franca may still have real effects on China, and deserves serious consideration. It shows mainly in two respects:

1. If the international lingua franca is not Chinese but remains English — that is, people of different mother tongues outside China use English as the bridge of communication — then the Chinese must still use English when communicating abroad. This means the state must ensure that a considerable share of its citizens possess foreign-language ability, supplying the labour market with workers, engineers, salespeople, researchers, and so on with a certain level of English. Since the demand exists, for the individual, learning English increases employment opportunities and is naturally meaningful. At least until 2040, China's university graduates will remain numerous and competition for white-collar jobs at home intense; if you cannot win the rat race at home, working for a Chinese enterprise going overseas is not a bad way out.

2. With China's ageing, after 2045 Chinese society will be deeply aged and will need to bring in large numbers of foreign workers. At that time, not only China but the whole of Europe, America, Japan, Korea, and Latin America will have entered deep ageing, also needing to import foreign labour or even immigrants. Since the total supply of labourers of a certain quality is limited, and the countries able to supply labour are themselves in rapid industrialisation and will consume a good deal of their own labour, the annual labour shortfall in the developed countries will reach the order of ten million.

Then, between the developed countries, there may appear a "scramble for talent" like the one between Chinese cities a few years ago. If the common language is not English, the newly imported labour will have received an education with little Chinese content and will very likely not know Chinese. If immigrants must learn Chinese in order to work and live in China, China's attractiveness to immigrants will be markedly reduced (other aspects may be attractive, but the language barrier will certainly be a minus). If promoting Chinese education abroad, in-house training in Chinese enterprises, and attracting foreign students to learn Chinese cannot fill the labour gap, then the state must consider raising the English proficiency of the Chinese people and building China into a bilingual society, to attract foreign workers and immigrants. The European countries — Germany, the Nordic countries, the Low Countries — have in fact already had to turn in this direction.

So the crux is: can Chinese replace English as the global lingua franca?

My answer is no. Chinese will become more popular around the world, but replacing English is nearly impossible.

The reasons:

Because English has already become the second or third language of most Europeans (at least the young), effectively playing the role of Europe's common language, China's strength must exceed not only America's but also that of America's allies. Hence the hardware condition for Chinese to replace English as the common language is that China's overall strength (economic scale, scientific output, etc.) exceeds Europe plus the five Anglo-Saxon countries. Even smoothly, China will not reach this level until about 2040. Let us analyse the global situation of the 2040s from the industrial and scientific angles.

From the industrial angle:

By 2040, the three newly industrialising regions behind China — ASEAN, South Asia (India, Pakistan, Bangladesh), and the Middle East (GCC, Egypt) — will have had a whole generation grow up in a world where English is the common language, deeply bound to English.

Among ASEAN, Singapore, the Philippines, and Malaysia are English-speaking countries to begin with; Vietnam, a non-English country, has decided to make English the foundation of the nation; what remains is mainly Indonesia. Indonesia's English education is also developing rapidly, with no sign of weakening. By 2040, English's influence in ASEAN will be greatly deepened. Of course, Chinese's presence in ASEAN will rise with the expansion of Chinese enterprises — rather like the position of Japanese in China a decade or two ago.

In South Asia, India and Pakistan need no elaboration — English is an official language. English-medium schools and bilingual schools are sprouting up like bamboo after rain, and higher education is basically in English. Bangladesh's English, from my own experience of communication, is quite

good as well. As Bangladesh joins the global industrial chains, the whole society's emphasis on English rises further. Nepal and Sri Lanka also have high English penetration. It may be said that, because of colonial history, English has penetrated every aspect of South Asian society; in the process of these countries joining global industrial chains, English's position can only strengthen. If the peoples of South Asia were to choose a global lingua franca, it could only be English.

The Middle East is a special case. The most developed GCC economies grew up in the era of globalisation: all their material factors of production, except land, come from abroad. Labour comes from South and Southeast Asia; equipment from China and other developed economies. Because of the extreme internationalisation of the factors of production, English penetration in the Gulf states is very high — Dubai is the typical city. In Egypt, English penetration is lower than in the GCC, but among the younger generation English education has become a hard necessity; the children of the local middle class almost all know English. In Jordan and Iraq, English education also ranks high.

And once these three newly industrialising regions have completed their industrialisation, considering the completeness of infrastructure, the educational level of the population, and the distance from the industrialised regions, the global industrial chains will very likely extend on a large scale into East Africa. And in the countries of East Africa, English is basically the language of education. Whether Rwanda and Ethiopia, which were never British colonies, or Kenya, Tanzania, and other former British colonies, English is the common language. When the industrial chains extend from South Asia and the Middle East into Africa, English naturally becomes the common language of communication among them.

From the scientific angle:

China's scientific output in the 2040s will very likely exceed that of Europe and America combined — but India's and ASEAN's, especially India's, will rise greatly.

If India could never develop, or developed 50 years behind China, leaving China enough time, then China might gradually replace English's position as the common language — starting with scientific research, then higher education, then industry, and finally spreading through the whole of society. But history has not given China this chance. India's rise in the middle of this century is inevitable. On India's rise, see my earlier answer:

"People keep saying don't look down on India, just as we once said don't look down on China — can India really pull off the next great-power rise miracle?" — answer by 最最遥远的路 on Zhihu: <https://www.zhihu.com/answer/1975983505159782474>

From the 2040s into the 2050s, China's scientific output cannot crush the sum of Europe, America, and India; and as the other industrial countries gradually increase their research spending, China's share — though still first — will see its relative advantage eroded. In such circumstances a strange

situation will appear: China is the number one in research, but is dragged by the other countries into publishing papers in English and conducting international academic exchange in English.

In sum: because English will continue to hold the position of common language, because globalisation will continue to develop, and because China will have to bring in foreign labour, learning English is meaningful for the Chinese, both at the national level and the individual level. In fact, since China has risen to become a world power, Chinese who have learned English can also go to other countries to teach Chinese — by then, the middle classes and above of various countries may have a considerable demand for learning Chinese. For the individual, mastering both Chinese and English will add many employment opportunities.

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